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FARMERS PROTEST AND THE VIRUS MUTATES

3 DECEMBER 2020

INDIA | 4,15,935 ACTIVE CASES | 1,40,161 DEATHS

WORLD | 1,39,12,137 ACTIVE CASES | 16,09,735 DEATHS

In the parliament session of September 2020, three bills viz. the Farmers' Produce Trade and Commerce (Promotion and Facilitation) Bill, the Farmers (Empowerment and Protection) Agreement on Price Assurance and Farm Services Bill and the Essential Commodities (Amendment) Bill were passed by both Houses following which they received the President's assent and acquired the status of laws.[1] Over the course of the next many months, the passage of these laws would become a political boiling point attracting protesting groups who were accused by some people as being responsible for the advent of the second wave of COVID-19 in India.

Indian agricultural policies, central and state, have over the years been based on food security concerns, i.e., adequate availability of food and strengthening the ability of citizens to access it. The aforementioned bills were long-pending reforms which would provide choices to farmers to sell agricultural surplus at lucrative prices and an opportunity for barrier-free, interstate exchanges in new trade areas and digital spaces. The bills would open up the agricultural sector to involve private players, thus improving competition and forcing the government-regulated Agricultural Produce Market Committees (APMCs) to become more efficient, which in turn, would improve price realization. However, as soon as the bills were passed, several groups of farmers' unions began to protest against them.